

Mouthful — Arcade Game 8 Design Document

Oct 2, 2026 · @Phillip Argall

Overview

Mouthful is a 3D eat-and-grow arena in the Deep Arcade: every player starts as a fry at the bottom of the food chain and eats their way up it, choosing a path at each fork, until they're the biggest mouth in the water or something bigger finds them. Up to 12 mouths share one reef (players plus bots), the round never stops, death sends you back to a fry, and the crown goes to whoever holds the top of the chain longest.

What it takes from Fish IO and the .io grow games: one round that runs continuously; eat what's smaller, flee what's bigger; a mass bar and a leaderboard; growth that unlocks forms with abilities; a crown for the king. **What it adds:** a true 3D ocean with depth as a dimension (the shallows, the reef wall, the open blue, the trench), Depth's living food web as the prey and the predators, six evolution paths with real trade-offs, and the fact that choosing wrong is funny (you can choose the blobfish).

Design pillars

1. **Everything is food or a mouth.** You, the bots, the players, the fish, and the things in the trench are all one chain. Size decides who eats whom; abilities decide who gets to use their size.
2. **Depth is strategy.** Shallow water is safe and poor; the open blue is rich and watched; the trench is where the largest things live and where the largest things are made. Where you swim is the first choice.
3. **Paths, not stats.** The six paths are different games: dash hunters, ink tricksters, armored sharks, floor-bound snipers, walking hazards, and the blobfish. Each fork is a commitment you feel immediately.
4. **Death is five seconds.** You respawn as a fry with a small head start and your path memory; the round is long enough to climb back and short enough that nobody holds the crown by sitting still.
5. **Silly and lethal.** Fish with faces, abilities with punchlines, and a leviathan in the trench that eats kings.

Session. A round is 15 minutes (lobby: 10 / 15 / 20). 2–12 players; empty slots are bots that play real paths. Score pays arcade tokens; tokens buy skins or spin the crate.

Tone. Depth's inked low-poly in bright water: the same ocean as Red Tide seen from the fish's side. Deaths are a gulp and a puff of scales. The blobfish is treated with respect by nobody.

The arena

One map, about 600 m across and 300 m deep, shaped like a reef shelf that drops into a trench. Depth is the arena's structure: each band has its own prey, its own predators, its own cover, and its own reason to be there.

Band	Depth	What's there	Who lives there	Why go
The Shallows	0–15 m	Sunlit sand, seagrass, a lagoon, mangrove roots, a pier with its pilings	Fry spawn here; tiers 1–2; small prey everywhere (minnows, shrimp, snails); the boat's shadow passes	Safe growth; the first fork; nowhere to hide from a tier-3 that comes in
The Reef	10–40 m	Coral heads, corridors, eel holes, a cleaning station, a wreck	Tiers 2–4; the busiest band; schools to eat, holes to hide in	The fastest growth in the game, and the most fights
The Wall	40–120 m	A vertical drop with caves, sponges, a kelp curtain at the top, an overhang at the bottom	Tiers 3–6; ambushers in the caves; crustacean paths own the ledges	Cover and verticality: dive down it to escape, climb it to hunt
The Blue	20–120 m, open water off the wall	Nothing but light, schools of bait, tuna, and the shapes that follow them	Tiers 4–7; no cover; the NPC apex sharks patrol	The richest eating and the most exposure; where kings are made and lost

Band	Depth	What's there	Who lives there	Why go
The Trench	120–300 m	Dark, vents, a brine pool, bioluminescence, the leviathan's hollow	Tiers 5–8 and the NPC leviathan; the only place to reach tier 8	The crown is won here and the leviathan eats whoever gets greedy

The living web

The arena runs Red Tide's ecosystem engine: about 25 prey and predator species with diets, blood, sound, and population. Prey schools move with the day (dawn and dusk bring bait up to the shallows and reef; night sends it down); predators follow blood; grounds that are overeaten empty out and refill. Players are species in the web: your kills bleed, your fights are noise, and the NPC sharks come to both. A round's ecology is the same for everyone and different every round.

Prey (free food)

Prey	Band	Mass	Note
Plankton cloud	Everywhere	1 per second inside it	A fry's first meal; a tier-5 can't be bothered
Minnow, shrimp, snail	Shallows, reef	2–4	Schools scatter from a charge
Sardine school	Reef, blue	3 each, 40 in a school	The grow engine for tiers 2–3
Crab, urchin, clam	Reef floor, wall	6–10	Crustacean path food; others break teeth (–5 mass per bite)
Mackerel, snapper, squid	Reef, blue	12–25	Tier 3–4 food; squid ink when bitten
Tuna, barracuda	Blue	40–60	Tier 4–5 food; they bite back
Rattail, anglerfish, hatchetfish	Trench	8–20	Trench food; anglerfish lure fry (they look like plankton)
Giant isopod, vent crab	Trench floor	15–30	Armored; crustacean food

Prey	Band	Mass	Note
Whale fall	Trench, one per round	300 total	A feast that draws every tier 5+ to one spot: the round's set piece

Cover and hazards

- **Hiding.** Eel holes (tiers 1-2), coral corridors (up to tier 3), wall caves (up to tier 5), the kelp curtain (anyone, until it's shredded), silt (crustaceans bury), ink.
- **Currents.** A surface current runs the shallows east; an upwelling off the wall lifts anything in it 2 m/s; the trench has a slow downdraft that costs stamina to fight.
- **Light.** The shallows and reef are lit; the blue dims with depth; the trench is dark except for bioluminescence and whatever you bring. Dark means short sight for everyone, which favors ambush paths.
- **The pier and the boat.** A fishing boat crosses the shallows and blue on a schedule: a net (drags anything tier 1-3 to the surface, which is death), a hook (bait that's a trap), and a chum line (free mass and a shark magnet).
- **The cleaning station** on the reef: fish there don't bite each other (a 10 m truce zone; attacking inside it marks you for the NPC sharks).
- **The brine pool** in the trench: 10 damage per second to anything in it; crustaceans float on it.

Growing

You have **mass**. Eating adds it; being bitten takes it; crossing a threshold grows you a tier, and tiers 2, 4, and 6 are forks where you pick a path. Size is what you can eat and what can eat you.

Tiers

Tier	Mass	Length	Can eat	Eaten by	Fork
1 Fry	0-29	10 cm	Plankton, minnows, shrimp	Everything	—
2	30-99	25 cm	Tier 1, sardines, snails	Tier 3+	Fork 1: choose a path
3	100-249	50 cm	Tiers 1-2, crabs, mackerel, squid	Tier 4+	—

Tier	Mass	Length	Can eat	Eaten by	Fork
4	250–549	1 m	Tiers 1–3, snapper, tuna (fight)	Tier 5+	Fork 2: the path's second form
5	550–1,099	2 m	Tiers 1–4, barracuda, trench fish	Tier 6+, NPC sharks	—
6	1,100–2,199	3.5 m	Tiers 1–5, NPC reef sharks	Tier 7+, the apex sharks	Fork 3: the path's final form
7	2,200–4,499	6 m	Tiers 1–6, apex sharks (fight)	Tier 8, the leviathan	—
8 King	4,500+	10 m	Anything but the leviathan	The leviathan, and three tier-7s together	The crown

Eating rules

- You can bite anything; you can **swallow** (kill and gain its mass) anything with less than 60% of your mass. Between 60% and 100% is a fight (bites take 10% of the target's mass per hit until one flees or is below 60%). Above 100% is a flee.
- Swallowing takes a 1 s animation during which you're slow; a tier-5 swallowing a tuna is a tier-6's moment.
- Prey mass is as listed; a player's mass is their bar, so eating a tier-4 at 400 mass is 400 mass, the fastest growth in the game, which is why players hunt players.
- Mass decays 1% per minute above tier 3 (big fish are hungry) and not at all below. A king who stops eating shrinks.

Forks

- **Fork 1 (tier 2):** pick one of six paths: Eel, Cephalopod, Shark, Crustacean, Pufferfish, Blobfish. The choice is permanent for this life.
- **Fork 2 (tier 4):** the path's second form (two options each, except the blobfish).
- **Fork 3 (tier 6):** the path's final form (two options each, except the blobfish).
- Dying resets you to a fry, but the game remembers your path: your next tier-2 fork offers the same path first (a free re-pick), and a **path streak** (three lives on one path) gives that path's forms +5% to their main stat.

The crown

The first player to tier 8 is **King** and wears the crown: +10% to everything, visible to all on the leaderboard and in the water (a glow), and a target: killing the king is worth their mass plus 500 and the crown passes. The crown is scored by time held.

The six paths

Each path is three forks deep: the path at tier 2, a second form at tier 4 (two options), a final form at tier 6 (two options). Stats are multipliers on the tier's base (speed, HP, bite). Every form has one **ability** on a cooldown and one **passive**. The blobfish has none of this and is proud.

1. The Eel path (reptile and eel): dashes

Long bodies that close distance. The hunt is a chase; the ability is the catch.

Form	Tier	Speed	HP	Bite	Ability	Passive
Moray	2	1.1	0.9	1.1	Dash: a 6 m burst in 0.3 s (4 s cooldown)	Hole-dweller: hides in any eel hole up to tier 3
Sea Snake	4	1.2	0.8	1.0	Dash (5 m, 3 s)	Venom: bites poison for 3 s (2% mass per s); surfaces to breathe every 60 s (a tell)
Conger	4	1.0	1.1	1.2	Lunge: a 10 m dash that bites at the end (5 s)	Drag: a bite on a smaller fish pulls it 3 m toward you
Marine Crocodile	6	1.0	1.3	1.4	Death Roll: a dash-grab that holds for 2 s and takes 15% mass (8 s)	Armored back: hits from above do half
Oarfish King	6	1.4	0.9	1.0	Ribbon Dash: three chained 8 m dashes (6 s)	Omen: nearby bots flee you; players see a ripple

2. The Cephalopod path (squid and octopus): ink

Soft, clever, and gone when you look. Ink blinds; the passive hides.

Form	Tier	Speed	HP	Bite	Ability	Passive
Reef Squid	2	1.2	0.8	0.9	Ink: a 5 m cloud that blinds for 3 s (6 s cooldown); you see through your own ink	Jet: speed +30% for 1 s after Ink

Form	Tier	Speed	HP	Bite	Ability	Passive
Octopus	4	0.9	1.0	1.0	Ink (bigger, 8 m, 4 s)	Camouflage: invisible while still for 1 s or more; a grab bite holds for 1 s
Cuttlefish	4	1.1	0.9	0.9	Dazzle : a flash that reverses an enemy's controls for 2 s (8 s)	Hover: no stamina cost to hold position
Giant Pacific Octopus	6	0.9	1.2	1.2	Ink Wall : a 15 m curtain for 6 s; nothing sees through it	Eight Arms: can grab two targets at once (hold 1.5 s each)
Colossal Squid	6	1.2	1.0	1.3	Hook Tentacles : a 12 m reach that pulls a target to the beak (7 s)	Trench-born: full sight in the dark

3. The Shark path: health

The straight line: more HP, more bite, no tricks. The passive makes blood work for you.

Form	Tier	Speed	HP	Bite	Ability	Passive
Dogfish	2	1.0	1.4	1.1	Frenzy : +40% bite for 3 s (8 s cooldown)	Blood sense: see blood trails 30 m
Bull Shark	4	1.0	1.6	1.3	Ram : a charge that knocks back 5 m and stuns 1 s (7 s)	Thick skin: -20% damage taken
Hammerhead	4	1.1	1.4	1.2	Pin : hold a target against the floor or wall 2 s (7 s)	Electroreception: see buried and hidden fish within 15 m
Great White	6	1.0	2.0	1.6	Breach : a vertical charge from below that deals 30% mass (10 s)	Apex: NPC sharks ignore you
Tiger Shark	6	1.0	1.7	1.4	Frenzy (longer, +60% for 5 s)	Iron stomach: eating armored prey costs no teeth; eats anything

4. The Crustacean path: the floor and the claw

Grounded: you walk, you can't swim up, you jump. Your claw reaches farther than anyone's bite, and your shell is a wall.

Form	Tier	Speed (walk)	HP	Claw	Ability	Passive
Mantis Shrimp	2	1.0	0.9	1.3 (range 3 m)	Punch: a 4 m snap that stuns 1 s (5 s cooldown)	Burrow: bury in sand or silt (invisible, 2 s to dig)
Spiny Lobster	4	0.8	1.3	1.2 (range 4 m)	Tail Flip: a 6 m backward jump (4 s)	Spines: melee attackers take 5% of their bite back
Coconut Crab	4	0.9	1.4	1.5 (range 4 m)	Jump: a 5 m leap in any direction, including up a wall face (5 s)	Crusher: eats armored prey freely; climbs walls
King Crab	6	0.8	1.8	1.6 (range 5 m)	Claw Slam: a 6 m shockwave along the floor that knocks swimmers up (8 s)	Fortress: -40% damage from the front
Giant Isopod	6	0.7	2.2	1.2 (range 3 m)	Roll: curl up: immune for 3 s, can't move (10 s)	Scavenger: corpses give double mass; the brine pool is water to you

Crustaceans can't enter open water: they walk the shallows, the reef floor, the wall's ledges (jumping ledge to ledge), and the trench floor. The blue is closed to them, and so are its tuna. They are the only path that holds a position.

5. The Pufferfish path: defense and payback

A fish nobody wants to bite. Slow, round, and expensive to attack.

Form	Tier	Speed	HP	Bite	Ability	Passive
Puffer	2	0.8	1.2	0.8	Inflate: double size for 3 s; can't be swallowed by anything under tier 5; 10% mass damage to any biter (6 s cooldown)	Spines: 3% mass damage to any biter at all times
Porcupinefish	4	0.8	1.4	0.9	Inflate (4 s, 15% damage)	Barbed: a bite on you leaves a spine: the biter bleeds 2% per s for 3 s
Boxfish	4	0.9	1.3	0.9	Toxin Cloud: a 6 m cloud that costs anyone inside 3% mass per s for 4 s (9 s)	Armor plates: -30% damage

Form	Tier	Speed	HP	Bite	Ability	Passive
Titan Puffer	6	0.7	2.0	1.0	Detonate: inflate and burst: 20% mass to everything in 8 m, and you drop a tier (12 s)	Untouchable: nothing under tier 7 can swallow you
Stonefish	6	0.6	1.6	1.5	Ambush: become part of the floor; the first bite from ambush deals 40% mass (10 s)	Venom spines: 10% damage to any biter, plus 5 s poison

6. The Blobfish path: nothing

Form	Tier	Speed	HP	Bite	Ability	Passive
Blobfish	2	0.7	0.9	0.8	None	None; it looks sad
Bigger Blobfish	4	0.7	0.9	0.8	None	Still none
Enormous Blobfish	6	0.7	0.9	0.8	None	A quiet dignity
The Blobfish King	8	0.7	0.9	0.8	None	The crown fits badly; a reaching tier 8 as a blobfish is the game's hardest achievement, worth 500 tokens and a skin nobody else can get

The blobfish's only edge is social: nobody takes it seriously, bots rate it as low-priority prey, and a blobfish at tier 6 is almost always left alone until it isn't.

Movement and combat

Swimming

- Third person behind the fish; mouse or stick steers in full 3D; W swims, shift boosts (stamina), space and ctrl pitch up and down for those who want them. Boost is the chase and the escape; stamina is 4 s at base and refills in 6.
- Base speeds by tier: 4 m/s at tier 1 rising to 7 at tier 5 and falling to 6 at tier 8 (big things turn slowly). Path multipliers apply. Turning radius grows with tier: a tier 7 can't follow a tier 3 through a coral corridor.
- Crustaceans walk at their listed speed, jump with space, and fall at 3 m/s; they can grip walls on the wall's ledges.

- Currents push; the upwelling is a free climb and a trap.
- The camera pulls back as you grow, so a king sees the whole reef and a fry sees the next rock.

Biting

- Left click bites in a cone in front of the mouth. Bite size scales with tier. A bite on something swallowable swallows it (1 s). A bite on something larger does the fight damage ($10\% \text{ of its mass per hit} \times \text{your bite stat} \times \text{their HP stat as a divisor}$).
- Bite cooldown 0.8 s at tier 1, 1.5 s at tier 8. Sharks bite faster in Frenzy; crustaceans claw at range instead.
- Hits on the tail do half; hits on the belly or gills do $1.5\times$ (the weak point; the camera tells you where it is).
- Being bitten knocks you back and drops 5% of your boost stamina.

Abilities

One per form, on the right mouse button, with the cooldowns listed; a ring on the reticle shows it. Abilities are the whole difference between paths and are tuned so that the same mass loses to a better-used ability about 60% of the time.

Fleeing

Anything above your mass is a flee. The game's honest advice: dive into cover you fit and they don't, use the ability, or boost toward the nearest bigger thing and hope it prefers them. A fish that reaches cover its pursuer can't enter is safe; a fish in open water against a faster path is food.

Death and respawn

- At 0 HP or on being swallowed you die: a gulp, your mass goes to the eater, your position goes on the kill feed.
- Respawn in 5 s as a fry in the shallows with a 10 s immunity glow (a bitten glowing fry marks the biter for the sharks), 15 starting mass (so the first tier-2 is a few minnows away), and your path memory.
- The leaderboard keeps your round score; dying costs you nothing you've already scored, only the mass you were carrying, which is the .io deal.

Blood and the web

Every bite bleeds into the ecosystem engine's scent grid; a fight that lasts 20 s draws the NPC sharks in the band; a kill is a corpse that the scavengers (and the Giant Isopod player) want. A player who kills a lot in one place is hunted by things that aren't players, which keeps kings moving.

Dangers that aren't players

The arena hunts back. The NPC predators are the ecosystem's; the boat, the currents, and the events are the designer's.

Danger	Where	Behavior	How to use it
Reef sharks (NPC, tier 5)	The reef and wall	Patrol; come to blood; eat tiers 1–4; calm within 10 m of the cleaning station	Lead a pursuer into their patrol; a Great White player is ignored by them
Apex sharks (NPC, tier 7: a great white, a tiger, a hammerhead)	The blue	Follow blood from far; eat tiers 1–6; a king can fight one (a long fight)	Kings hunt them for mass; everyone else leaves the blue when the music changes
The Leviathan (NPC, tier 9)	The trench's hollow	Sleeps; wakes to blood or noise in the trench; eats anything, including the king, in one bite; sleeps again after eating	It's why the crown can't be held in the trench forever; a king lured to the hollow by a fleeing fish is the round's best play
The orca pod (NPC, tier 7, event)	Passes through the blue once a round	Hunts the three largest things on the leaderboard for 90 s, then leaves	Shrink below the top three by hiding; or let it eat the king

Danger	Where	Behavior	How to use it
The boat	Shallows and blue, on a schedule shown by its shadow	Nets (tiers 1-3 are hauled up and die), hooks (bait that holds for 3 s and takes 20% mass), the chum line (free mass and sharks)	Boost under the net's edge; bite the hook's line to free a friend; chum is a trap for whoever's second to it
Currents	Shallows (east), the upwelling, the trench's downdraft	Push, lift, pull	Escape routes and ambush lanes
Red tide (event)	Shallows and reef, 60 s	A bloom that blinds everyone in it and kills prey schools (free corpses)	Cephalopods love it; pufferfish hate it (inflate does nothing in the dark)
The whale fall (event, once)	The trench floor	300 mass of feast; every tier 5+ bot and apex shark comes	The round's melee; the leviathan wakes if it goes on too long
Night	Every round has a dusk at 10 minutes	Light drops; bait rises; ambushers' sight advantage grows	The shark and cephalopod paths' hour
The eel garden	A patch of the reef floor	Bites anything tier 1-2 that passes within 1 m	A fry's first lesson

NPC predators are real agents in the food web with hunger and territory; they don't scale with the leaderboard, so the top of the chain is dangerous because the trench is, not because the game is adjusting.

Match structure

The round

- 15 minutes by default. Everyone spawns as a fry in the shallows at 0:00; the orca pod passes at a random minute between 5 and 10; dusk at 10:00; the whale fall at 11:00; the final minute is **high tide**: mass decay stops, the leviathan sleeps, and the leaderboard is pinned on screen.
- Players join late as fry with a mass head start equal to the lowest living player's mass (capped at tier 3).
- Bots fill to 12 and play real paths with three difficulty levels; they're named like fish ("Gary", "Brinefloat", "The Admiral") and have the same kill feed as players.

Scoring

Score	Points
Mass eaten (total over the round)	1 per 10
Player kills	50 each, +25 per tier the victim was above you
Crown held	10 per second
King killed	300
Highest tier reached	50 per tier past 4
Apex shark killed	200; the leviathan 1,000 (nobody has)
Survived the orca pod while in the top three	100
Round won (highest score at high tide)	200
Blobfish King	500, and the skin

The leaderboard shows score and current tier; the crown shows who's king. Tokens pay on score and firsts.

Modes

Mode	Rule
Mouthful (default)	As designed
Blobfish Only	Everyone's a blobfish; the first to tier 6 wins; nobody has abilities and everyone is sad
One Path	The lobby picks one path for everyone (Shark Night, Crab Day)
Trench Rush	The round starts at tier 4 in the trench; 8 minutes; the leviathan is awake
Food Chain	Teams of 3 share a path and a score; killing a teammate's prey feeds the team
King of the Reef	No respawn for the king: lose the crown and you're out; last crown standing
Solo Tank	One player, bots, and a longer round for learning the paths

Strategy

The paths are built as a rock-paper-scissors-and-then-some; the arena's bands are where each one wants to fight. This is the meta the balance pass aims for.

Who beats whom (equal mass)

Path	Beats	Loses to	Why
Eel	Pufferfish (dash in, bite the belly, dash out before the spines matter), Blobfish	Cephalopod (ink ruins a dash), Crustacean on the floor (the claw out-ranges the lunge)	Burst at range, thin HP
Cephalopod	Eel, Shark (ink and camouflage: a shark can't frenzy what it can't see)	Crustacean (ink doesn't stop a claw slam), Hammerhead (electroreception)	Control, no sustain

Path	Beats	Loses to	Why
Shark	Crustacean in open water (it can't follow), Cephalopod when it can see	Pufferfish (every bite costs), Eel in corridors	HP and bite, no tricks
Crustacean	Eel, Cephalopod on the floor; anything that comes down to it	Anything that doesn't; Shark in the blue	Range and armor, no mobility
Pufferfish	Shark, bots, anything that bites a lot	Eel (hit and run), Cephalopod's toxin-free control, being ignored	Payback, no offense
Blobfish	Nothing	Everything	It's a blobfish

Where to be

- **Tiers 1-2:** the shallows and the reef's edges; eat schools; take the first fork by where you want to live.
- **Tier 3-4:** the reef; crustaceans hold the floor and the wall ledges; eels hunt the corridors; cephalopods hunt the eel holes' neighbors; sharks start going to the blue; pufferfish graze and get left alone.
- **Tier 5-6:** the blue for sharks and eels (tuna); the wall for everyone else; the whale fall at minute 11 pulls everyone to the trench.
- **Tier 7-8:** the trench to finish growing, then out of it, because the leviathan.

The king's problem

A king decays 1% a minute, is visible to everyone, and is worth 300 plus their mass. Kings that hide shrink; kings that hunt bleed. The intended king play is a circuit: the blue for tuna, the reef edge for a mid-tier kill, back to the blue, never the trench after the crown. The intended regicide is three tier-5s with abilities, or one fleeing fish and a patient leviathan.

Reading the other paths

Every form has a silhouette and a tell: eels' bodies coil before a dash; squid go pale before ink; sharks' pectorals drop before a ram; crabs raise a claw; puffers have a visible intake before inflating; the blobfish has no tell because it does nothing. A player who reads tells

wins the equal-mass fights the design says they should.

The blobfish, honestly

A blobfish wins by being ignored: bots rate it as low-value, players laugh, and a blobfish that reaches the whale fall at tier 5 and eats the corpses nobody wants can be an Enormous Blobfish by high tide. The Blobfish King is reached about once in forty rounds by the people who try, which is the right number for a skin nobody else can get.

Progression and cosmetics

Tokens buy skins that apply to every form on a path (a skin is a palette and a pattern, plus a hat for the forms that can wear one) and nothing else. Same structure as the other arcade games: a token shop and a crate.

Tokens

10 per round, 1 per 100 score, 20 for a round won, 30 for a first crown on a path, 500 for the Blobfish King.

The token shop (10 skins)

Skin	Cost	Look
Reef Camo	50	Coral mottle; hides a little better in the reef (visually only)
Deep Glow	80	Bioluminescent dots
Tiger Stripe	80	
Pearl	100	Iridescent white
Red Tide	100	The blood-red palette
Brass Plated	120	Rivets and verdigris, the Nautilus look
Ghost	150	Translucent, the Drowned's palette
Goldfish	150	Orange, bowl-shaped eyes
The Captain	200	A tiny bicorn on every form
The Crown Jewels	250	Gold and gems; the crown fits it perfectly

The crate (40 skins)

One token, one crate (a clam that opens). Duplicates are a pearl of no value. Odds: Common 60% (15, 4% each), Rare 25% (10, 2.5%), Super Rare 12% (10, 1.2%), Special 3% (5, 0.6%).

Tier	Skins
Common (15)	Sardine Silver, Sandy, Kelp Green, Sunset, Lagoon, Mud, Clownfish Orange, Zebra, Spotted, Rusty, Slate, Bubblegum, Neon Sign, Camo Net, Grandpa (a monocle)
Rare (10)	Sushi (rice on the back), Toy (a wind-up key), Lava, Ice, Disco Ball, Pirate (eyepatch and a parrot that is also a fish), Cardboard Box, Lego-ish Blocks (brick-textured), Carp Flag (streamers), Haunted (a chain and a moan)

Tier	Skins
Super Rare (10)	Dragon (scales and horns), Robot Fish (the Clockwork look), Skeleton, Galaxy, Lantern Fish (a working lamp on every form), Shark Suit (every path looks like a shark; the panic is real), Kraken Ink (your ink is purple and your skin matches), Gold Statue, The Submarine (a tiny Nautilus hull), Wearing a Smaller Fish (a hat that is a fish)
Special (5)	The Blobfish King (only from reaching it; sad and radiant), The Leviathan's Tooth (a scar and a glow; given to the first to deal 10% to the leviathan), The Chef (a toque and a knife; every swallow is a chop sound), The Sun God's Mask, The Matriarch (orca patches on anything, even the crab)

Skins are data (`mouthful_skins.json`) and share the arcade token with the other games; the Shark Suit and the Blobfish King are the two skins players will talk about.

Presentation, technology, and bots

Look

- Depth's inked low-poly underwater, bright in the shallows and reef, dim in the blue, dark in the trench with bioluminescence. Red Tide's renderer, fog, caustics, and marine snow.
- Every form is a `CreatureBuilder` body plan from Red Tide's art workbook (fusiform, anguilliform, cephalopod, shark, crab, puffer, and a blob) with path palettes; growing a tier scales the mesh and swaps the form at forks with a 1 s morph (a shimmer and a new silhouette).
- Faces: every form has eyes that track prey and a mouth state; the blobfish's expression never changes.
- The camera pulls back with tier; the reticle shows bite cone, ability ring, and the weak-point marker on a target.

Simulation and networking

- The host runs the ecosystem (Red Tide's engine: 25 species, about 400 active agents), the NPC predators, the boat, events, and the bots.
- Host-authoritative through the shared arcade layer: local prediction for the player's swimming; bites resolved on the host with 150 ms of lag compensation; 20 Hz snapshots with interest management by distance and the band's visibility.
- 12 players is the design cap; join-in-progress is supported (fry spawn with the head start).

Bots

Bots play the paths with three levels: Minnow (eats prey, flees everything bigger), Hunter (hunts players a tier below, uses abilities, avoids the trench), Shark (reads tells, baits abilities, goes for the king). Bots fill empty slots and never outnumber players in the top three of the leaderboard (a Shark bot that would take the crown throttles itself unless the mode says otherwise).

Save

The arcade profile stores rounds, best tier per path, crowns, skins, and the Blobfish King flag.

Sound design

- **Bands have beds:** surf and gulls in the shallows, the snapping-shrimp crackle of the reef, a wide quiet in the blue, the vents' hiss and the pressure drone in the trench.
- **Growth is heard:** your own swim gets heavier with tier; a tier-8's tail is a slow whoosh and the fry you pass flutter away.
- **Bites:** a snap for a miss, a wet crunch for a hit, a gulp for a swallow (bigger with the mass), and the chomp of the king.
- **Abilities each have a voice:** the dash's whip, the ink's blurt, the frenzy's thrum, the claw's snap and the slam's thud, the puffer's intake and squeak, the detonation's pop, the stonefish's silence (the one ability with no sound; its tell is visual only).
- **Danger:** the apex sharks have a two-note motif that enters when one's within 40 m; the orca pod's clicks; the leviathan's single deep note when it wakes, which everyone in the trench hears and acts on; the boat's engine and the net's hiss.

- **The crown:** a brass fanfare when it's taken; a slow drum while it's held; a crash when the king dies.
- **Music:** a bright reef theme that darkens by band and tempo-shifts with your tier; dusk brings the night layer; high tide brings a countdown; the blobfish has its own four-note theme, in a minor key, that plays whenever one is on screen.

Build order, data, tests, and open questions

Data files

File	Holds
<code>mouthful_tiers.json</code>	Mass thresholds, lengths, base speeds, bite cooldowns, decay
<code>mouthful_paths.json</code>	Six paths, every form: stats, ability, passive, body plan, palette
<code>mouthful_arena.json</code>	Bands, cover, currents, the boat's schedule, events, the cleaning station
<code>mouthful_sea.json</code>	The 25 species and diet matrix (Red Tide's format), NPC predators, the leviathan's script
<code>mouthful_scoring.json</code>	Score, modes, token payouts
<code>mouthful_bots.json</code>	Bot behaviors by level
<code>mouthful_skins.json</code>	Shop, crate, odds

Build order

Stage	Work	Gate
1	A fry in the shallows: 3D swimming, boost, bite, swallow, mass, tiers 1-3; prey on Red Tide's engine	Eating minnows feels good for five minutes
2	The arena: all five bands, cover, currents, the wall; the first fork and two paths (Shark, Eel)	A fry grows to tier 6 alone

Stage	Work	Gate
3	Multiplayer and bots: 12 in a round, respawn, the leaderboard, the crown	Six players finish a 15-minute round on LAN
4	The other four paths with every form; abilities; tells	<code>--mouthful-duel</code> shows the counters table
5	NPC dangers: reef and apex sharks, the leviathan, the boat, the orca pod, red tide, the whale fall, dusk	A king dies to the leviathan in testing
6	Modes, skins, crate, sound, internet play, balance pass	All targets met or logged

Tests

- `--mouthful-duel <formA> <formB> <mass>` fights two forms at equal mass with scripted ability use; asserts the counters table within 55–65%.
- `--mouthful-round <bots> <minutes>` runs a bot-only round and reports: time to first king, crowns changed, deaths by cause, tier reached per path, whether the leviathan ate anyone.
- `--eco-sim mouthful <minutes>` for the arena's web.

Balance targets

- A competent player reaches tier 4 in 3 minutes, tier 6 in 7, and the crown in 11 if nobody stops them.
- Equal-mass duels follow the counters table at 55–65%; mirror matches are 50 ± 3 .
- The crown changes hands 3–6 times in a 12-player round.
- Deaths by cause at the end of a round: players 60%, NPC predators 25%, the boat and hazards 10%, the leviathan 5%.
- The Blobfish King is reached about once in 40 rounds by players who try.

Open questions for the designer

- ☐ Should a dead king's crown drop as an item to be picked up, or pass directly to the killer as written?
- ☐ Should paths be lockable in the lobby (a player always starts on their path) or always chosen at the first fork?

- ☐ Are crustaceans allowed to ride the upwelling (a swimmer's lane) as an exception, or truly floor-only?
- ☐ Should there be a second arena later (an open atoll, a kelp forest), or seasons of species for this one?